

SOUNDCARDS

Until recently, system integrators and branded computers alike, did not pay much attention to the audio subsystem. As long as one could attach stereo speakers to the computer, that was all the audio needed. However, things have changed—with the integration of advanced audio processing in most motherboards, entry-level users can enjoy multi-channel sound, with some budget cards even boasting Dolby Digital compliance. This is corroborated by the fact that most entertainment applications such as games and movies are now authored using more than two channels of audio. Due to this convergence, most sound systems today are integrated directly into the motherboard in the form of a codec. The main processor handles the audio processing and in some cases, discrete audio processors are built into the motherboard. While this has been consolidated by a number of soundcard manufacturers, some prefer to go with dedicated external soundcards.

Are you listening?

Numerous factors affect the performance of a soundcard, such as the frequency response, S/N (signal-to-noise) ratio and the MIDI implementation. Good soundcards have a frequency response of 20 Hz to 20 KHz with an S/N ratio of 80 dB. The wider the frequency response and the greater the S/N ratio, the better the soundcard. Another important characteristic is the extent to which the soundcard depends upon the main processor while in operation. Ideally, a soundcard should be able to handle all audio requirements independently. However, in reality, the soundcard uses some part of the main

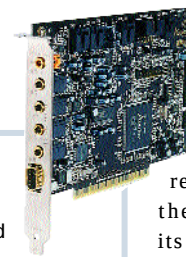
Nominees

Name	Contacts	Comments
Creative SB Live! DE 5.1	Compuage Infocom Ltd, Ph: 022-23842200	With brilliant performance in multi-channel audio for movie gaming, this sound card is a for home theatre systems
Zoltrix Nightingale PRO 6	Kunhar Peripherals Pvt Ltd, Ph: 022-22345758	Sporting 4-channel support & low CPU utilisation scores, the card delivers plenty of performance even at a low price

CPU's power while in operation. Go for a card where the utilisation is not more than 5 per cent. Though the difference is significant with newer processors, it could be noticeable when you upgrade the soundcard into an older machine.

The features that a soundcard supports are just as important as choose a soundcard that supports at least four channels and a standard such as EAX or A3D, as these standards are used in many of today's games.

Finally, make sure the soundcard can drive your speakers—some high-end speakers have a provision for line input and your soundcard should have a similar output for the same level of audio quality.



Creative Audigy Platinum
Compuage Infocom Ltd,
Ph: 022-23842200

The verdict: This soundcard has 24-bit digital audio playback, robust audio interface support and 5.1-channel support. It hits the highs in gaming and movie performance

And the award goes to

The soundcard that shatters records in performance and claims the Creative Audigy Platinum. Thanks to its support for true 5.1 channel Dolby Digital support, 24-bit audio quality and very low CPU utilisation, this soundcard performed excellently in all the applications.

SOUND EDITING

Sound Forge 6.0

With digital audio, very few tools come close to the capability and power of Sound Forge. This robust audio editing software incorporates a vast range of tools to let you perform basic audio editing on digital audio such as copying, pasting, and lengthening and shortening audio files. In addition, it offers full 32-bit file support, with sample rates from 2 KHz to 192 KHz, giving very high-quality audio. The zoom ratio for working with audio has also been increased to 24:1 to let you edit the waveform on even a sample level. The new multitasking environment allows the application to render in the background while you are editing other files in the foreground, saving

precious bits of your time. There is also a set of 35 preset effects such as flanging, chorus, reverb, etc, that help to add a dimension of depth to your audio tracks.

With professional-quality audio editing features and a host of controls and effect capabilities, Sound Forge 6.0 is your ticket to mastering audio at the home or in



Sound Forge 6.0
Sonic Foundry,
E-mail: customerservice@sonicfoundry.co

The verdict: One of the most powerful Wave editing tools around, the application boasts unparalleled features and functionality for creating and processing audio effects